by Afghan President Hamid Karzai, UN Secretary General Ban Ki-Moon, and British PM Gordon Brown, the conference marked the beginning of the Afghan war's end. Focusing on security, development and governance, and regional cooperation, the conference sought to influence the Taliban to shun violence and start a dialogue with Kabul.[67] Just a one-day affair, the conference was pivotal in the history of the Afghan war. It did not change the course of the war, as the Taliban continued with its strategy of coercion, but it changed the calculus of all other regional and global actors involved in Afghanistan, as well as that of the Afghan government. Just like Gorbachev had decided in the fateful November 1986 politburo meeting that the USSR was to prepare for an exit from Afghanistan, the West agreed on a similar course of action in London that day. The idea of talking to the Taliban was anything but new (James Jones had informed Singh already). Informally, all fighting parties were in touch in some form or the other. Having challenged the US approach of talking to the Taliban, India had been expecting such a turn of events since the very first Taliban attack in 2003. What it had not hoped for, however, was the ready acceptability of the West's advocacy of reconciliation.

On 29 January 2010, the *Times of India* reported: the 'World Rejects India's Taliban Stand' that there are no degrees of Talibanism.[68] The report resented the conference's lack of focus on accommodating former UF leaders including Abdullah (an absurd statement given that Abdullah was well entrenched in Afghanistan's mainstream politics). Nonetheless, it reflected India's discomfort with the changing political tide in Afghanistan. Complicating India's position further, soon after the London conference, Turkey hosted the first political meeting of the 'Heart of Asia' process (also called the Istanbul conference), from which New Delhi was excluded at Pakistan's request.[69] Initiated by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Afghanistan (MoFA), the Istanbul process marked the thrust of Afghanistan's foreign policy imperatives in the region seeking cooperation between Kabul and its neighbours on security and economic issues.[70] India took offense to Ankara's decision to keep India out of the process under Pakistan's pressure. On 2 February 2010, just before John Kerry's visit to New Delhi, Roemer told Washington that 'India was kept out of the Istanbul regional conference on Afghanistan (based on Pakistan's veto) and New Delhi was the